I was up. Next moment, I was down. To repeat, through this period, I really didn't have a clear idea what was going on.

Colin Dettmer, the Tukkies coach, was adamant that he paid no attention to schoolboy reputations or provincial selection; as far as he was concerned, youngsters just out of school needed to prove themselves before playing in the university 1st team. That was his policy and he stuck to it. That was fair enough.

'Where are we meeting tonight?'
'News Café at nine?'
'OK, I'll see you there.'

So the student life continued, interspersed with sporadic moments when I would see or hear something on the cricket field that made me stop and think. On one occasion, playing for the Northerns B team, I arrived at the Technikon ground to find Quentin Still, a senior player, reading a newspaper. I sat beside him and tried to engage this experienced player in conversation ... without success. He eventually turned to me and said gravely: 'Young man, we score our runs after lunch.'

Barely out of school, I was far too scared to ask what on earth he meant. It took me some time – perhaps too much time – to understand his point that, in cricket, it's usually wise to keep things tight in the morning and the runs will flow more easily as you become more settled.

'Menlyn is going to be quiet, so let's go to the DropZone?'
'In Hatfield? No problem, I'll be there.'

The telephone was ringing for a second time.

'AB, it's Dave Nosworthy here. I'm calling to let you know you have been selected for the South African Under-19 tour to England in June.'

'Thanks.'